The Record Retention Program is the rudder of RM boat

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1. Record Retention Program

Retention program is like a rudder on record management boat. It guides the record management into the right voyage direction. Without retention program, record management undoubtedly is like a blind person who walks in a dark night. Hence, Retention program plays very important role in record management. The primary thing, every record manager should consider, is how to design an efficient and effective retention program to keep record management in a healthy way. Retention program (Mary, Gerald, David, 1996), in usual, consists of record management policy and main retention schedule.

Undoubtedly, record management policy is like a general outline to frame the most important aspects in record management. It not only involves the basic objective, and principles of record management, but also embraces the aspects, such as how to handle the duplicate records, how to deal with the record ownership, how to build retention schedule, how to destruct the record which exceed the retention period, how to access the record, and finally how to cope with record related with litigation-holds.

Retention schedule is like an instrument panel in delicate machine. Before doing anything, the driver or operator must check the panel, and according to the parameter on it to determine what the next step is. In the same way, record manager must put retention schedule as a main or core reference before he or she determine whether going into next phase. Like the technician must periodically check whether the panel is in a good condition, the record manager also should periodically checks the effectiveness of retention schedule and updates or modifies them

according to changed situation. Hence, retention schedule is located in a very important core position in whatever retention management policy or record retention program.

2. Identify Arena

For the reason of important position the retention schedule hold, the primary thing which record manager should pay attention to, is how to build an appropriate retention schedule according to context.

In normal situation, the retention schedule in different industry and areas, have different characteristics and features. Although the basic components are nearly same, they definitely have some different places where distinguish them from each other. Like different kinds of car are merely suitable to drive on correspondent road status, the different industry should have related retention schedule. Failing to consider the concrete situation one organization locates, will result in a deadly problem.

Hence, it is very important for record manager to clearly tell the differences among different areas and industries, such as academic research institute, large corporation company, non-profit organization, government and correspondent agencies, university and school systems, libraries, law companies, and so on. Then, according to differences, record manager designs or fashions different kinds of retention schedule to adapt corresponding context. There is definitely no panacea to accommodate or conform to all of the instances. From this meaning, record manager undertake the role of architect.

3. Building Process

In order to build a successful retention schedule and policy, record managers should abide by standard work process. Simultaneously, they must employ relatively flexible way to adapt to

concrete situation, on the one hand to guarantee the completion of retention schedule and policy building, on the other hand to increase the efficiency of building process.

The building process should encompass the restrictive steps, and several important aspects should be called attention. The first, a good building plan, combining the strategy analysis and context statement, is the first step of success. The second, a clear and fresh goal is definitely required as a lighthouse in building process. The third, there must have an outline or blueprint on how to complete the building process step by step. The fourth, without doubt, research is a prerequisite and solid foundation on building a qualified and refined retention schedule. The fifth, under complex company politics, it is definitely a kind of art to capture the support from employees in different departments, and undoubtedly it is extremely consequential to rally surrounding departments, and persuade or convince the potential opponents through education. The sixth, the quality control is very significant in generating a top-quality retention schedule and related policy. The seventh, a retention schedule and policy should be adequately or fully implemented to guarantee reaching the original goal (Mary, Gerald, David, 1996), which record manager set up.

During the process, there are some places record manager should take cautions, such as how to solve the scalable problem on record series, how to promote record committee formation, how to deal with things related with special retention policy, how to deal with ESI (electronically stored information), how to update record retention schedule according to environment change, how to keep the policy following the strategy, how to make retention schedule and policy to be compliant with complex and diversified organization structures.

3.1. A good record retention schedule and policy should be built on the basis of compliant with company or organization strategy.

Record retention schedule and policy must be coincident with the company or organizational strategy. In usual, strategy status is like the importance of constitution for a country. Strategy not only decides the development direction of company or organization (Porter, 1985), but also is a detailed guide on what can be done, what can not be done. Without doubt, strategy is the soul of a company or organization. Hence, without support from the strategy, without coincident with the strategy, the record retention schedule and police building will meet great obstacle and destined to be a failure. So, a good record retention schedule and policy must be compliant with company or organization strategy.

3.2. A clear and fresh goal is definitely required as a lighthouse in the process of building retention schedule and policy.

After the confirmation and definitude of the strategy, record manager should place their focus on how to realize the strategy through the concrete goals. “The goals of an organization are established at the highest levels of management; goals reflect the philosophy and aspirations of management for the entire organization” (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992). In normal situation, goals are the concrete components of strategy, a litter down on the status compared with strategy. Subsequently, under the goals, the objectives are the specified layer of the goals, and it is relatively easy to manipulate in operation layer.

In fact, retention schedule and policy, not only should request to be compliant with strategy, but also should be in cooperation with the phase goals and specific objectives. Without compliance with concrete goals and objectives of companies or organizations, retention schedule and policy will lost its meaning of existence.

On the execution layer, a detailed plan is required, for record manager, to arrange the time limit and apply related resources on different phases of retention schedule and policy building.

As a guide of concrete work, this plan will save valuable time and assist record manager preparing enough resources to complete work.

3.3. There should have an outline or blueprint on how to accomplish the building process step by step.

The first, record manager should have a deep understanding on the resources organization or company has (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992). Undoubtedly, before record manager do anything, he or she must know what this organization or company have. The best way to achieve this is to make a detailed survey on records and inventory under the support of top managers.

The second, record manager should get the agreement from others managers, especially those who have compact relationship with record management department. So, record manager must understand that without the agreement or cooperation from other managers, it is nearly impossible to push the retention schedule and policy building into success.

The third, following the two steps ahead, record manager should implement an inventory survey (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992) in order to master the record status. Under this situation, record survey form is a powerful weapon or tool to collect record information, such as record type, location, department, size, year, range, volume, person responsible for files, contact person, whether it is copies, retention requirement, and so on.

The fourth, after collecting the information, record manager must make a deep record analysis on the material collected (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992). Because of different interpretation coming from departments, the collected data requests to be cleansed and standardized. Then a detailed classification based on data summary should be made, on the one hand, as a requirement of mastering information, on the other hand, as a basis of building record series in later step.

The fifth, following the steps already completed, a preliminary work must be done to ensure the later retentions schedule work completed in a smooth way. During this period, a detailed record appraisal (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992) based on evaluation must be done. However, the basic evaluation principle, including administrative value, fiscal value, legal value, and historical value, should be employed to ensure a perfect record series, and accurate retention periods to be built.

The sixth, record manager completes the retention schedule, simultaneously modifies and refashions them through the communication with the related department. Record manager should adjust and makes an experiment version of retention schedule and related policy. Then, these schedule and policies are sent to related departments to review. After receiving review results and advices, record manager complete and determine the final version of retention schedule. Although it is called final version, it still requires collating and modifying in future, being compliant with the environmental changes periodically.

3.4. The fourth, without doubt, research is a prerequisite and solid foundation on building a qualified and refined retention schedule and policy.

Research is a kind of art. Without research, retention schedule and policy is nothing. On the one hand, record manager should be diligent to do a research on related federal, state, and local regulation and law; on the other hand, record manager should positively invite professionals or managers from other departments to give advices or evaluation on retention schedule and policy. Without doubt, it is also a good way to borrow some merit from other similar organizations or companies.

During research process, record manager should reconsider the appropriateness of record series (Mary, Gerald, David, 1996). In general, if record series is too much fragmented, record

manager is hard to handle and manipulate the related retention schedule on it. Under this situation, it not only increases the work load, but also decreases the precision of the related work. However, if record series is too much sketchy and shallow, it can not satisfy the administrative requirements, and it is hard to allocate reasonable retention schedule on appropriate record level. In this way, it may leave the companies in danger because some important records are mixed with other ones, and can not be shredded in time. Hence, it is very important to control the "sifter-hole size" to congregate records in an appropriate level, not only to improve the work efficiency, but also to increase the precision of record management.

In order to make retention schedule easily handled, record manager must differentiate between general retention schedule and specific ones (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992). General retention schedule is the one common to many departments. However, specific retention schedule is the one unique to one department. It is meaningful to distinguish between general retention schedule and specific schedule. In this way, the relationship between different kinds of retentions schedule is much more reasonable. Simultaneously it is relatively easy to update retention schedule in the unit of block. Combining the general and specific retention schedule together forms the comprehensive schedule of a department. By using this block-building method, it not only improves the work efficiency of record manager, but also makes schedule modification relatively easy than before.

3.5. The fifth, under complex company politics, it is definitely important to capture the support coming from managers in different departments, and undoubtedly it is extremely consequential to rally other departments which have a close relationship with record management.

Record manager should build a friendly and compact relationship with other departments, in case of decreasing the obstacle on retention schedule and policy fashioning. The decision making process within large corporation or organization, usually has some fixed habit or custom, such as that director may like to collect opinion from every department, then make a decision. Under this situation, it is very important for record manager to hold a good relationship with managers in other departments. Simultaneously, record management department should rally with other department, on the one hand provide better services to other departments, and on the other hand achieve their support on retention schedule and policy making.

However, it is very possible that record manager will meet or encounter some people who refuse to abide by the retention policy. Fox instance, there always have some people who would like to preserve everything forever. Under this situation, a good communication and education procedure is definitely required to persuade them to correct behavior. Furthermore, a top down company support, especially one coming from record management committee, will take great effect in persuading some stubborn clerk to comply with the retention schedule and policy.

Actually, record manager not only require fighting with stubborn individuals, but also need to fight with the conservative work habits in organization. Some traditional or conservative routine way is very hard to break through. Under this situation, record manager not only need the help from company culture management department, but also demand the help from top decision layer. In many occasions, a complete discussion is a better way to help throwing away the old pedantic habit. Without doubt, record management committee is a perfect organizational form to open and carry through this kind of discussion topic. Record management committee consists of professionals, managers, even directors from every department, simultaneously having the privilege to provide advices and recommendations to board meeting or CEO. Hence, it is a

perfect way to persuade stubborn individuals and departments to change their work habit through the decision made by this committee.

3.6. The sixth, the quality control is very significant in generating a top-quality retention schedule and related policy.

Quality control not only should take effect in the process of building retention schedule and policy, but also should play an important role in updating and refreshing old schedule and policy. In normal situation, the environment is always changing. When this kind of change reach to some gate level, the corporation or organization must update and refresh their retention schedule and policy to keep up with the change. So, building a quality control system is very significant in generating a top quality retention schedule and related policy.

3.7. The seventh, a retention schedule and policy should be completely or fully implemented to guarantee reaching the original goal, which record manager set up.

Once upon a final decision has been made by board meeting or record management committee, every person and department should abide by it without exception (Betty, Ann, Kay, 1992). The audit department should ensure the related procedure implemented in a perfect level.

The record retention schedule and related policy with high quality should be distributed into individuals and related department. In this way, every person and department have acknowledged that, and understand the responsibilities to abide by them in daily works.

4. Some special consideration

4.1. Record manager should be cautious on the aspect of adopting big bucket theory.

Sometimes, with the healthy record management system already built, it is no need to employ big bucket theory. Big bucket theory (Miller, 2008) means decreasing the workload of record management by reducing, simplifying, or combining the record series. However, it is

definitely unwise to adopt big bucket theory in most situation, on the one hand, it increase the risk which record manager undertakes, on the other hand, it unnecessarily lower the qualify control standard. From another angle, if the Record management system can easily assist record manager to complete work related with normal retention schedule and policy, why do we take risk to simplify them. Actually, big bucket theory merely lowers the difficulties of record management software complying, but with the cost of increasing the risk faced to record manager. Hence, it is not advisable to adopt big bucket theory in most situations.

4.2. It is a big challenge to make full use of retention schedule and policy at the corporation with complex structure.

The quick changing environment in large corporation is a big challenge for record manager to make full use of retention schedule and policy. The frequent acquisitions and merges in business market greatly requires record management to use block management method, on the one hand abide by the work process of retention policy, on the other hand easily transfer the archives and record in unit of block. In most situations, before deep planting retention schedule into the company newly merged, record manager must have acumen on corporation strategy (Porter, 1985), and smell easily what the real target of merge it is. If some merges come from the strategic consideration and the merged units will be sold out very quickly, it definitely have no need to waste big energy to inject their records in.

However, for the reason of complicacy in business world, record manager must have clear mind to keep up with faster step of company strategy, and some deep analytical method is definitely required for them.

5. Conclusion

In conclusion, Record management program is definitely required for an organization. It is important to build the retention schedule and policy to increase the efficiency of record management, on the one hand make a contribution on strategy implementation, and on the other hand decrease the risk company or organization taken. Without doubt, the correct retention schedule and policy building process is the guarantee of successful record management.

Reference

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